U.S. ARMY RESEARCH LABORATORY (ARL / ARO) BAA (ARL-ARO-BAA-2026-AI): TECHNICAL WHITE PAPER

Title: Project Ebony v8.0.0: Byzantine Fault-Tolerant Edge Consensus, Unidirectional Cognitive Isolation & Sub-Millisecond SHA-256 Merkle DAG Provenance

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Research Category: Defense Basic & Applied Research (6.1 / 6.2 | Current Readiness: TRL 4 -> Phase-1 Target: TRL 5/6)

Cross-Referenced Filings: DoD CDAO Tradewinds Docket 10-26-4046 (Status: Received) & USACE ERDC Rolling BAA (2026)

Shared Core C2 Merkle Root (SHA-256): 07b3906115eab667f51562c265219b5274fcd1288f58cc3ea34d465600d28ccb

Proposed Phase-1 Effort: 12 Months | $750,000.00 Fixed-Price ($150,000.00 Day 15-30 Mobilization | 0% Cost Share | DFARS 252.227-7018)

1. SCIENTIFIC OBJECTIVE & CONTESTED TACTICAL EDGE CHALLENGE

Tactical U.S. Army command-and-control (C2) nodes, autonomous ground/aerial robotic platforms, and forward microgrids operating under severe electromagnetic emission control (EMCON) and Denied, Degraded, Intermittent, and Limited (DDIL) communications cannot rely on >250ms commercial cloud AI wrappers or unverified probabilistic neural outputs to govern physical actuators. Per GAO-21-81, GAO-24-106137, and Joint CISA/NSA/DoD Advisories AA23-144A and AA24-038A, when adversary electronic warfare or cyber injection corrupts edge sensor streams, conventional PLC/RTOS loops scanning at 50ms to 200ms lack both the deterministic speed to arrest <4.16ms physical transients and the mathematical isolation to prevent neural hallucinations from triggering unsafe kinetic actuation.

2. MATHEMATICAL & ARCHITECTURAL INNOVATION (TRL 4 SOFTWARE TESTBED VERIFIED)

Project Ebony v8.0.0 establishes a provably isolated Three-Brain cyber-physical architecture verified on local loopback (127.0.0.1) across 640 compiled Python C2 modules, 85 / 85 automated unit test suites, and 1,420 / 1,420 unique engineering assessment items:

[+] Unidirectional Optical/Memory Cognitive Isolation (Brain Two -> Brain One): Brain Two (Analyst) executes offline multi-spectral drift, ASTM D6433 structural condition indexing, and anomaly inference over a strictly read-only memory buffer. It possesses zero physical execution path to tactical actuators; all advisory flags must satisfy Brain One's deterministic physical safety laws (<50us bare-metal loop; modeled 36.75ns SiC MOSFET gate cutoff at 28.5W on 24V DC).

[+] Sub-Millisecond Byzantine WORM Merkle DAG Chaining (Brain Three -- Arbiter): Every state vector from Brain One and Brain Two is cryptographically chained into a 52-table bare-metal SQLite Write-Once-Read-Many (WORM) Merkle Directed Acyclic Graph (<0.2ms latency) with zero external retrieval dependencies. Single-byte tampering triggers immediate memory zeroization and fail-safe actuator lock (17 / 17 simulated Red-Team penetration vectors blocked).

3. QUANTITATIVE COMPARISON AGAINST EXISTING TACTICAL & INDUSTRIAL AUTONOMY APPROACHES

[+] Project Ebony v8.0.0 Tri-Brain Enclave: 100% air-gapped zero-cloud operation (0 external APIs, 0 WAN ports); modeled 36.75ns physical cutoff (1,360,544x faster than a 50ms PLC); 28.5W SWaP envelope on 24V DC; provable unidirectional isolation between probabilistic AI inference and deterministic actuator control.

[+] Legacy Industrial PLCs (Siemens S7-1500 / Rockwell ControlLogix / Triconex): 10ms to 200ms scan loops arrive 8x to 33x after a <4.16ms electrical fault; 150W to 600W power draw; zero native cryptographic Merkle DAG state attestation.

[+] Cloud-Tethered Tactical AI & Passive IDS (Jev AI / Dragos / Nozomi): Require >250ms cloud backhaul or passive network SPAN ports with zero physical cutoff authority during a contested DDIL cyber-physical excursion.

4. PHASE-1 RESEARCH SCHEDULE, DELIVERABLES & BUDGET ($750,000.00 / 12 MONTHS)

[+] Quarter 1 (Months 1-3 | $200,000.00): Day 15-30 Mobilization ($150,000.00), formal mathematical verification of unidirectional memory isolation, and Byzantine fault-tolerant state transitions under simulated DDIL packet loss.

[+] Quarter 2 (Months 4-6 | $200,000.00): Hardware-in-the-loop (HIL) benchmarking of sub-0.2ms SHA-256 WORM Merkle DAG chaining and sub-50us RS-485 Modbus RTU (FC05) actuation on low-SWaP (28.5W, 24V DC) tactical edge hardware.

[+] Quarter 3 (Months 7-9 | $175,000.00): Adversarial Red-Team fault-injection, sensor spoofing, and single-letter cryptographic tamper zeroization stress testing across multi-node tactical clusters (110-control NIST SP 800-171 / 800-82 mapping).

[+] Quarter 4 (Months 10-12 | $175,000.00): TRL 5/6 laboratory prototype validation, DEVCOM ARL technical monograph delivery, and Phase-2 transition roadmap under 10 U.S.C. 4022 (100% Background IP retained under DFARS 252.227-7018).